

People often lose muscle as they age, partly because they're less active, so it's good to know that exercise, even when you're older, can reverse the muscle-loss process. When you're older, you can still get results, but you need to work harder for them than when your body was 10 years younger.

Help with staying active

So, if you don't want to gain weight, or if you want to lose it, the key is to increase your level of activity. You may need help to get you started or to keep you moving. If so, there are many professionals you can turn to.

A personal trainer is one. He or she may do some or a combination of the following, according to your needs: a thorough fitness assessment, a specially tailored exercise program, make regular visits to work with you

and check you're staying on track. Of course, a personal trainer is not a low-budget option.

A less expensive choice is to join a gym and work with an instructor there. He or she will show you how to use the various items of fitness equipment safely and will also assess your weight, your percentage of body fat (see p.178), your lung capacity, and your flexibility. You'll be given a tailor-made fitness program to follow, and every 6 to 8 weeks you can usually have a re-assessment, which will monitor your improvement. Then your fitness program can be tweaked as required.

Seeing a good osteopath or physical therapist can also be extremely helpful for getting you on the right track. He or she can identify any problem areas you might have—such as stiff knees or hips—or any that you might develop in the near future, for example if you spend all day hunched over a computer. Such advice is priceless since not

Resistance training is what you need to help build lean muscle and improve your lean-muscle-to-fat ratio (see p.99). Your muscles have to work against a weight, for example a weighted ball, known as a “medicine ball,” as shown here. Alternatively, you can work against gravity, using your own body weight in exercises such as squats or push-ups.

